

John Archibald Wheeler, ca. 1954. [Photo by Blackstone-Shelburne, New York City; courtesy J. A. Wheeler.]

Wheeler worked in much the same mode as had Oppenheimer, with an entourage of students and postdocs. From among them he selected B. Kent Harrison, a serious-minded Mormon from Utah, to work out the details of the equation of state for cold, dead matter. This equation of state would describe the details of how the pressure of such matter rises as one gradually compresses it to higher and higher density—or, equivalently, how its resistance to compression changes as its density Increases.

Wheeler was superbly prepared to give Harrison guidance in computing the equation of state for cold, dead matter, since he was among the world's greatest experts on the laws of physics that govern the structure of matter: